

DIGITAL STORYTELLING

COMM 3 · SANTA CLARA UNIVERSITY · FALL 2026

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Communication Department

Vari Hall 206

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OFFICE HOURS

Tuesdays 9:30 to 11:30 am, and

[by appointment](#)

CLASS MEETINGS

MWF 8:00 to 9:05 am

MWF 10:30 to 11:35 am

Vari 133

READINGS

On the class site,

classes.andrewishak.com/comm3

This course will challenge you to become an educated consumer and creator of stories in the digital age. During the quarter we will learn to identify the basic elements of narrative design and how to create stories using different platforms. We will spend a great deal of time learning how to analyze audiences and assess the best storytelling strategies to connect with them while considering the power and privilege of the creators. Along the way, you'll learn how to record a concise audio story, make a visual story, and create a multimedia portfolio.

I want two things for you by the end of the quarter. First, when you read a story, whether it is about an athlete or a political event, you understand how the medium, the viewpoint, and the decisions behind the telling shape what you are reading. Second, and more important, you can do it yourself. Podcasts, video, and multimedia are the forms we use, but the underlying point is that whenever anyone tells a story, the choice of medium, what gets included, and the point of view all matter.

WEEK	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENT
1	Identifying stories and framing	Identifying stories and framing exercise
2	Visual language	Visual language exercise
3	Graphics	Visual story pre-production, Friday. Graphics exercise
4	Narrative arc	Visual story
5	Characters	Characters exercise
6	Audio quality	Audio story pre-production, Friday. Audio exercise
7	Audience and platform	Audio story
8	The final project	Groups form Wednesday
9	Pitches and production	Groups pitch Monday
10	Editing and presentations	Groups present Wednesday. Final pre-production document
Finals		Final project, Wednesday, December 9
		Class culture, ongoing

Exercises are due Sundays. Pre-production for the visual and audio stories is due the Friday nine days before the project. Pre-production for the final is due the night of the group presentations, Wednesday, December 2. Pre-production counts toward the project it belongs to, not toward the creative exercise grade.

Creative exercises are always individual. The visual story and the audio story are done in pairs. The final project is done in groups of four.

Each piece gets a whole letter grade. There are no pluses or minuses on individual assignments and students do not see percentages. The final course grade is built from the letters lined up together, read for the average and for growth across the quarter.

You can find dates and more information at classes.andrewishak.com/comm3.

Department Learning Outcomes

The course objectives meet the following Department Learning Outcomes:

LO 1 Explain and apply communication theories and concepts.

LO 3 Analyze communication structures that maintain power and privilege and engage in practices that support diversity, equity, and inclusion.

LO 4 Analyze the ethical dimensions of communication and form judgments and practices based on evidence and values.

LO 6 Create effective and ethical oral, visual, and written communication based on awareness of diverse perspectives, contexts, and social identities.

LO 7 Design communication that fosters a more just, humane, or sustainable world.

Course objectives

1. Identify and understand basic narrative elements. (LO 1)
2. Identify a target audience and the best platform or distribution channel to connect with the audience. (LO 1)
3. Critically analyze the power and privilege of content creators. (LO 3, 4)
4. Create research-based social justice stories using an audio story, a short video, and a multimedia project. (LO 6, 7)

Course assessment

COURSE OBJECTIVE	LOS	ASSESSED BY
Identify and understand basic narrative elements.	1	Creative exercises, visual story, audio story, final project
Identify a target audience and the best platform or distribution channel to connect with the audience.	1	Audio story, final project
Critically analyze the power and privilege of content creators.	3, 4	Creative exercises, final project
Create research-based social justice stories using an audio story, a short video, and a multimedia project.	6, 7	Visual story, audio story, final project

Accommodations

If you have a documented disability for which accommodations may be required in this class, please contact Disabilities Resources, Benson 216 (www.scu.edu/disabilities) as soon as possible to discuss your needs and register for accommodations with the University. If you have already arranged accommodations through Disabilities Resources, please initiate a conversation with me about your accommodations during my office hours within the first two weeks of class.

Students who are pregnant and parenting may also be eligible for accommodations. Accommodations will only be provided after I have verification of your accommodations as approved by Disabilities Resources, and with sufficient lead time for me to arrange testing or other accommodations. For more information you may contact Disabilities Resources at 408-554-4109.

Late Work

Over many years of teaching, I have gone through a number of different policies regarding late work. What I've found is that the best policy is to be consistent, clear, and simple. This might seem strict to you, but again, this is what I've found to work the best.

If an assignment is not turned in at the deadline, the student will receive an F for that assignment. This includes turning in the wrong assignment, a mostly-incomplete assignment, or an assignment that doesn't meet basic requirements.

Then, the regrade policy applies. So the best a late assignment can earn is a D.

Regrading

If you would like to earn a higher grade, you may re-submit your assignment within 48 hours of receiving your grade. A resubmission can raise your grade by one letter.

Some assignments will not have improvement opportunities, including those submitted during Finals Week, and presentations. Please keep that in mind as we make our way towards the end of the quarter.

Plagiarism

Plagiarism and cheating in any form is unacceptable in this course, as it is in any course at SCU. There are no excuses. If you plagiarize or are found to be academically dishonest in any way, you will receive a grade of zero on that assignment. For incidents that I consider to be exceptional, you will receive a failing grade for the course. We'll talk about what counts as plagiarism, but if you're unsure in the meantime, come talk to me, or see scu.edu/academic-integrity.

AI

We'll have a conversation about AI in class. Otherwise, my expectation is that we will use AI to assist us when I call it appropriate.

Use of Classroom Recordings

Some class meetings may be recorded by the instructor and made available on the class site. As is stated in the Student Conduct Code: "...Dissemination or sharing of any classroom recording without the permission of the instructor would be considered 'misuse' and, therefore, prohibited. Violations of these policies may result in disciplinary action by the University. At the instructor's discretion, violations may also have an adverse effect on the student's grade."

Discrimination, Harassment and Sexual Misconduct (Title IX)

SCU faculty are committed to helping create a safe and open learning environment for all students. If you (or someone you know) have experienced any form of discrimination, harassment or sexual misconduct, including sexual assault, dating or domestic violence, or stalking, know that help and support are available, I encourage you seek support and report incidents to the Director of Equal Opportunity and Title IX Coordinator, Belinda Guthrie, at 408-554-3043, bguthrie@scu.edu. For more information about reporting options and resources at Santa Clara University and in the community, please visit scu.edu/title-ix. If you wish to speak with a confidential resource, please visit scu.edu/title-ix/resources/student.

Copyright Statement

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Technology Support

For Zoom assistance, contact Media Services at mediaservices@scu.edu or 408-554-4520. You can also get support from the Zoom Help Center website.

For SCU network and computing support, contact the SCU Technology Help Desk at techdesk@scu.edu or 408-554-5700. They can provide support for MySCU Portal, Duo, eCampus, hardware and software issues, and more.